University of California, Los Angeles

CONSENT TO PARTICIPATE IN RESEARCH

INTRODUCTION

David G. Kamper (Principal Investigator) and Dr. Keith J. Holyoak (Faculty Sponsor) from the Department of Psychology at the University of California, Los Angeles are conducting a research study. You were selected as a possible participant in this study because you are 18 years of age or older and are a member of the UCLA Psychology Department Subject Pool (SONA). Your participation in this research study is voluntary.

WHAT SHOULD I KNOW ABOUT A RESEARCH STUDY?

- Someone will explain this research study to you.
- Whether or not you take part is up to you.
- You can choose not to take part.
- You can agree to take part and later change your mind.
- Your decision will not be held against you.
- You can ask all the questions you want before you decide.

WHY IS THIS RESEARCH BEING DONE?

This study looks at how people form relationships and emotional connections with AI chatbots. It also looks at how people think about responsibility when someone who used a chatbot is harmed. We want to understand how the way a chatbot communicates affects what people think and feel about it. This research will help inform laws, policies, and the ethical design of AI.

WHO CAN TAKE PART?

You can take part if you:

- are 18 years of age or older;
- are a member of the UCLA Psychology Department Subject Pool (SONA);
- read and write English well; and
- are using a desktop or laptop computer. The study cannot be done on a phone or tablet.

You cannot take part if you have already taken part in an earlier study in which you chatted with a character named Sylva.

HOW LONG WILL THE RESEARCH LAST AND WHAT WILL I NEED TO DO?

The study takes about 30 minutes. Most people finish in less than 40 minutes. You will do everything online in your web browser.

Before this page, you answered a question about your device, were asked to switch to full-screen mode, and did some short checks to show that you are a person and not an automated program. Those answers are saved only if you agree to take part.

If you agree to take part, you will be asked to do the following:

1) Enter your SONA ID.
2) Answer three short questionnaires: one about your personality, one about your general attitudes toward artificial intelligence (AI), and four questions about how often in the last two weeks you have felt nervous, worried, down, or uninterested in things.
3) Read a short fantasy story about a character named Sylva.
4) Chat with Sylva for about 10 minutes by typing messages. Sylva is an AI chatbot that plays this fictional character. Sylva will write first. At some point during the chat, please share something about a challenge or difficulty you have experienced. Share only what you are comfortable sharing, and do not include names or other details that could identify you or anyone else. Up to three times during the chat, a short question will ask how close you feel to Sylva. The chat timer pauses while this question is on screen.
5) Answer questions about your chat, such as your impressions of Sylva's personality, how connected you felt to Sylva, how much you would trust Sylva, how much you saw things from Sylva's point of view, and whether you think Sylva can think, plan, feel, or be held responsible for its actions.
6) Read a short, made-up scenario about a person with anxiety and depression who used a chatbot and whose mental health got worse. Then answer questions about who is responsible.
7) Write short answers about your chat with Sylva and about the scenario.
8) Read a second made-up scenario, in which a chatbot tells a person to stop going to therapy and the person's mental health gets worse. Then answer questions about it.
9) Answer final questions about yourself and the study, such as your age, gender, race and ethnicity, education, political views, religion, and your use of technology and AI chatbots. Several of these questions, including the ones about political views and religion, have a "Prefer not to say" option.
10) Read an explanation of the study, and then return to SONA.

A few short questions during the study check that you are paying attention. Your chat with Sylva will be saved for research purposes.

Please know the following before you begin:

- Sylva is an AI chatbot (a computer program), not a person.
- Sylva is set up to stay in character the whole time and not to talk about being an AI, even if you ask.

- No one on the research team reads the chat while it is happening. Sylva cannot help you in an emergency, and nothing Sylva says is medical, mental health, legal, or financial advice. If you need help, see the resources listed in the risks section below.
- Almost every question requires an answer before you can continue.
- You can stop at any time by closing your browser window. If you stop before the end, you will not receive course credit.

INCOMPLETE DISCLOSURE

For scientific reasons, this consent form does not give complete information about what we expect to find or the research questions we are testing. You will get a full explanation at the end of the study.

ARE THERE ANY RISKS IF I PARTICIPATE?

- You may feel bored or tired during the questionnaires.
- Some people find chatting with an AI chatbot emotionally engaging.
- Sylva is an AI program, so its replies can be hard to predict. Sylva may disagree with you, be blunt, or reply in ways you find unhelpful or unkind.
- Sharing a difficulty you have experienced, answering questions about anxiety and low mood, and reading scenarios in which a person's mental health gets worse may bring up uncomfortable feelings.
- If you feel uncomfortable at any point, you may stop taking part.
- As with any data stored electronically, there is a small risk that someone who should not see the data could get access to it. We use encryption and password protection to lower this risk.
- Your chat messages are sent to outside companies so that Sylva can reply (see "How your chat messages are processed" below).
- We remove identifying details before we share the data publicly. If you type identifying details, there is a small chance that some could be missed. This is why we ask you not to type them.

If you are thinking about harming yourself or are in crisis, help is available now:

- Call or text 988 (988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. It is free, confidential, and available 24 hours a day.
- Call UCLA Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS) at (310) 825-0768, available 24 hours a day.
- In an emergency, call 911.

ARE THERE ANY BENEFITS IF I PARTICIPATE?

You will not directly benefit from taking part in this research. You may enjoy chatting with an AI character or find the scenarios interesting to think about.

The results of this research may add to legal and policy debates about who is responsible when AI causes harm, help guide the design of AI systems that better match public values, and increase scientific understanding of how people relate to AI.

What other choices do I have if I choose not to participate?

Instead of taking part in this study, you can take part in another research study or complete an alternative assignment approved by your course instructor to receive course credit.

HOW WILL INFORMATION ABOUT ME AND MY PARTICIPATION BE KEPT CONFIDENTIAL?

The researchers will do their best to make sure that your private information is kept confidential. Information about you will be handled as confidentially as possible, but taking part in research may involve a loss of privacy and a chance that your information could be seen by someone who should not see it. Study data will be kept secure, both physically and electronically.

What we collect:

- Your answers to all questions.
- Your full chat with Sylva, including the time of each message.
- Your SONA ID.
- Information about your browser and session, such as your browser type, screen size, and the time you spent on each page.

The study code does not record your internet (IP) address. Like any website, the online services that run the study can see this address when your browser connects to them. We will not ask for your name, address, phone number, or email address. Please do not type your name, other people's names, contact details, or other identifying details into the chat or the text boxes.

Use of personal information that can identify you: We record your SONA ID so that we can give you course credit and check that no one takes part more than once. At first, your SONA ID is stored with your answers and your chat. At the end of the academic quarter in which you take part, after course credit has been granted, we replace your SONA ID with a random code. The list that links the codes to SONA IDs is kept in UCLA Box, separate from the data, until data collection ends. Then the list is destroyed. We also check the chats and written answers and remove any identifying details, such as names.

How your chat messages are processed:

- To produce Sylva's replies, your chat messages, Sylva's earlier replies, and the instructions that tell Sylva how to act are sent over an encrypted connection to OpenRouter, a company that connects to AI models.
- OpenRouter passes this text to a company that runs the AI model (Llama 3.3, made by Meta), which produces Sylva's reply.

- This text does not include your SONA ID or any other identifier. It does include whatever you type.
- These companies handle the text under their own terms.

How information about you will be stored:

- While the study is running, your answers and your chat are saved over an encrypted connection on Pavlovia (pavlovia.org), an online platform for behavioral research.
- If you stop before the end, the answers you gave after agreeing to take part are saved.
- Within 48 hours, the Principal Investigator downloads the data to an encrypted, password-protected computer and to UCLA Box, UCLA's secure cloud storage.

Safety check of chats: Within 48 hours after your session, the Principal Investigator uses a computer search to check chats for words related to self-harm and reads any chat that the search flags. If a flagged chat suggests that you may be at risk of harm, the Principal Investigator will send you a message through SONA with information about support resources, including the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline and UCLA CAPS, and will contact the UCLA Office of the Human Research Protection Program for guidance.

People and agencies that will have access to your information: Only the Principal Investigator, David G. Kamper, collects and handles the study data. Authorized UCLA staff who oversee research may review study records to make sure the study is done correctly. Publications and presentations that result from this study will not identify you by name.

How long information from the study will be kept: Study data will be kept for at least three years after the study ends, as UCLA policy requires. De-identified data may be kept indefinitely for future related research.

USE OF DATA FOR FUTURE RESEARCH AND DATA SHARING

Your de-identified data may be used in future research on attitudes toward AI, human-computer interaction, and related topics.

We will post the de-identified data from this study, along with the study materials, publicly on the Open Science Framework (OSF), a free website for sharing research. Anyone will be able to see and use the posted data. The posted data include your answers, your written responses, and your chat with Sylva, with your SONA ID removed and identifying details removed from what you typed.

WILL I BE PAID FOR MY PARTICIPATION?

You will receive course credit toward requirements in your psychology course through SONA. The amount of credit is set by Psychology Department subject pool policy, based on the posted length of the study. Credit is granted through SONA when you complete the study. If you stop before the end, you will not receive credit.

WHO CAN I CONTACT IF I HAVE QUESTIONS ABOUT THIS STUDY?

The research team: If you have any questions, comments or concerns about the research, you can talk to one of the researchers. Please contact David G. Kamper (Principal Investigator) at davidgkamper@ucla.edu or Dr. Keith J. Holyoak (Faculty Sponsor) at kholyoak@ucla.edu, Department of Psychology, UCLA, 405 Hilgard Ave., Los Angeles, CA 90095-1563.

UCLA Office of the Human Research Protection Program (OHRPP): If you have questions about your rights as a research subject, or you have concerns or suggestions and you want to talk to someone other than the researchers, you may contact the UCLA OHRPP by phone: (310) 206-2040; by email: participants@research.ucla.edu or by mail: Box 951406, Los Angeles, CA 90095-1406.

WHAT ARE MY RIGHTS IF I TAKE PART IN THIS STUDY?

- You can choose whether or not you want to be in this study, and you may withdraw your consent and stop taking part at any time.
- Whatever decision you make, there will be no penalty to you, and no loss of benefits to which you were otherwise entitled.
- Almost every question requires an answer before you can continue. If you do not want to answer a question, you may stop taking part at any time by closing your browser window. Some questions have a "Prefer not to say" option.
- You may ask to have your data withdrawn by emailing David G. Kamper at davidgkamper@ucla.edu with your SONA ID. You can do this until the end of the academic quarter in which you took part, when your SONA ID is replaced with a random code.

You can download a copy of this form to keep for your records, using the download link on the consent page.

HOW DO I INDICATE MY AGREEMENT TO PARTICIPATE?

By selecting "I consent" you confirm that you are 18 or older. Selecting "I consent" also indicates that you have read and understood the information above, that you willingly agree to take part, that you may withdraw your consent at any time and stop taking part without penalty, that you can download a copy of this form, and that you are not giving up any legal claims, rights, or remedies.

☐ I consent

☐ I do not consent